AI Skills Explained

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title: AI Skills Explained
video no: 18 of 30
series: Building an AI Business From Scratch
voice_reference: ../../Input/4. Resources/2. scripting_resources/voice_reference/nate_herk_voice_reference.md
video_type: concept
hook_type: Curiosity-Gap
script_versions: A + B
status: DRAFT
```

REFERENCE VIDEOS

- CLAUDE CODE FULL COURSE 4 HOURS: Build & Sell (2026) (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QoQBzR1NIqI) -- Nick Saraev -- Watch for how Nick creates reusable instruction sets for repeated tasks -- this is the skill pattern in practice
- "I built 500+ AI agents, here's everything I know" (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Svp7fbF0g2I) -- Nate Herk -- Watch for how Nate externalises task knowledge into reusable agent components rather than repeating instructions
- Claude Code Hooks: A Practical Guide (https://www.datacamp.com/tutorial/claude-code-hooks) -- DataCamp -- Read for the connection between skills and hooks: skills define the how, hooks trigger the when

THE ONE THING

Skills files are reusable instructions that make your AI agent better at specific tasks without re-explaining them every session -- write once, apply always.

HOOK

Every time you tell Claude how to write in your voice, or how to format a report, you are repeating yourself. A skills file fixes that permanently -- and it is 15 lines of markdown.

TARGET VIEWER

Someone using Claude Code or AI agents for repeated tasks who finds themselves copying and pasting the same long instructions into every session -- or writing long system prompts for tasks that should be standardised.

PAYOFF

After watching, the viewer knows what a skills file is, can write one for the task they repeat most, and immediately reduces the friction of their regular Claude workflows.

BEAT STRUCTURE

Beat -- The Re-Explanation Problem

Point: For every repeated task, you either re-explain the instructions or copy-paste from last time. Neither scales. Skills files give Claude a reusable instruction set it can pull on demand.

Visual: Two terminal sessions: session 1 (long prompt explaining the task in detail), session 2 (just say "use the report skill") -- same quality output, fraction of the input

Target words: ~120w

Beat -- What a Skills File Is

Point: A skills file is a markdown file that defines how to do a specific task: the steps, the format, the tone, the edge cases. Claude reads it at the start of the task and applies it.

Visual: Skills file open in editor: a "write weekly summary" skill with format, required sections, tone notes, and what to skip -- 15-20 lines total

Target words: ~160w

Beat -- Skills vs System Prompts

Point: A system prompt is temporary -- it lives in the conversation and disappears. A skills file is persistent -- it lives in your project, is versioned with your code, and can be updated over time.

Visual: Side-by-side: system prompt in chat window (disappears when session ends) vs skills file in project folder (permanent, editable, versionable)

Target words: ~150w

Beat -- How Skills Compose

Point: You can chain skills in sequence -- research skill, then drafting skill, then formatting skill. This is how a multi-step workflow becomes a reliable repeatable pipeline.

Visual: Three skills files in a /Skills/ folder; terminal showing agent reading each in turn and combining the outputs into a finished deliverable

Target words: ~160w

Beat -- Writing Your First Skill

Point: Pick your most repeated task. Write the steps you always follow. Add the format you always use. Add the things you always tell Claude not to do. That is your first skill -- 15 lines is enough.

Visual: Live demo: blank file, write a simple skill from scratch for one specific repeated task, reference it in Claude, watch it apply

Target words: ~150w

Beat -- CTA Bridge

Point: Skills define how Claude does things. Next: Hooks -- how to trigger skills and rules automatically at specific workflow events, without manually invoking them.

Visual: Preview clip from AI Hooks Explained

Target words: ~60w

ANALOGY BANK

- Skills file: Like a recipe card -- a chef does not reinvent pasta every service. They have a recipe. The

skills file is Claude's recipe for your repeated tasks: consistent, improvable, shareable.
- Skills vs system prompt: Like the difference between giving a contractor a verbal briefing (for this job) vs handing them a documented SOP (for every job of this type). The briefing is ephemeral; the SOP is institutional.

THESIS LINE LOCATION

Beat 2 -- The insight is: a skills file externalises your expertise into Claude's context -- once written, you never have to explain that task again, and the skill improves with each edit.

FRAMEWORK PHRASE

Write once, use always

SPECIFICITY BANK

- Skills files are plain markdown -- no special format required
- Reference them in CLAUDE.md so Claude knows they exist: "Skills are in /Input/2. Skills/"
- Organise by domain: /Skills/writing/, /Skills/research/, /Skills/formatting/
- Skills files persist through context compaction like CLAUDE.md
- An agent can be instructed to read a skill file at the start of each task via a simple CLAUDE.md instruction

CONSTRAINTS

- Do not confuse with Claude.ai product "skills" feature (if it exists) -- this is about custom markdown files
- Do not go into hooks in this video -- those are next
- Keep examples grounded in real daily tasks: report writing, research, formatting -- not abstract AI concepts
- Do not explain sub-agents or multi-agent workflows -- keep it single-agent focused

CTA DIRECTION

Skills define how Claude does things. Next: Hooks -- how to trigger skills and rules automatically at specific workflow events, without you manually invoking them each time.

PERSONAL ANGLE [DANIEL TO FILL]

Suggested: The first skills file you wrote and what it automated -- and how many sessions you had been re-explaining that same task before you wrote it down.

VULNERABILITY MOMENT [DANIEL TO FILL]

Suggested: A skills file that was too vague and produced inconsistent results -- the specific thing you had to specify precisely before it worked reliably every time.
Note: belongs in Beat 5